

A Note on Pronunciation

Reading the Pali Terms in This Book

Throughout this book, a number of Pali terms appear in their original spelling — “Nibbāna”, “sati”, “jhāna”, “anattā”, and many others. Pali is the canonical language of Theravāda Buddhism and was the language in which the Buddha's teachings were first preserved in writing. The pronunciation is straightforward once a few marks are understood. You do not need to memorize this page; use it as a reference whenever a word seems unfamiliar.

Vowels

Vowels with a horizontal mark above (a "macron") are held approximately twice as long as vowels without one. The sound is otherwise the same.

Short	Long	Sounds like
a	ā	as in "father" (short and long)
i	ī	as in "pin" → "machine"
u	ū	as in "put" → "rude"
e	—	as in "they" (always long)
o	—	as in "go" (always long)

Consonants with Dots Below (Retroflex)

A dot beneath a consonant indicates it is "retroflex" — pronounced with the tongue curled slightly back to touch the roof of the mouth. English does not have this sound naturally, but an ordinary t, d, n, or l is close enough for reading purposes.

ṭ	—	a t pronounced with the tongue curled back
ḍ	—	a d pronounced with the tongue curled back

ṇ	—	an n pronounced with the tongue curled back
ḷ	—	an l pronounced with the tongue curled back

Nasal Consonants

Certain consonants carry a subtle nasal quality, marked with a dot above, below, or a tilde.

ṁ	—	a nasal hum, like the "ng" in "sing"
ṅ	—	the "ng" sound, as in "sing"
ṇ	—	like the Spanish ñ or the "ny" in "canyon"

Aspirated Consonants

Consonants written with an "h" after them are pronounced with a small puff of breath. The h is not silent. Thus *dh* is not the "th" of "this" — it is a d followed by a soft h. Similarly, *bh* is a b with a breath, *kh* is a k with a breath, and so on. English speakers should simply say the consonant and allow a gentle exhalation to follow.

Examples from This Book

Here are a few of the key terms used throughout this book, with a simple guide to their pronunciation.

Anattā — *ah-NAHT-tah* (non-self)

Anicca — *ah-NEE-chah* (impermanence)

Ānāpānasati — *ah-nah-pah-nah-SAH-tee* (mindfulness of breathing)

Dhamma — *DHAHM-mah* (the teaching)

Dukkha — *DOOK-kah* (unsatisfactoriness)

Jhāna — *JHAH-nah* (meditative absorption)

Nibbāna — *nib-BAH-nah* (extinction, liberation)

Paṭiccasamuppāda — *pah-tich-chah-sah-moop-PAH-dah*

(dependent origination)

Saṃsāra — *sahm-SAH-rah* (the cycle of existence)

Sati — *SAH-tee* (mindfulness)

Samādhi — *sah-MAH-dee* (concentration)

Tipiṭaka — *tee-PEE-tah-kah* (the Pali Canon)

Vipassanā — *vee-pahs-sah-NAH* (insight meditation)

A Simple Rule

If you are unsure how to pronounce a word, say it with confidence and even rhythm, holding long vowels slightly longer, and the meaning will carry. The Pali sages cared more for the practice than for perfect pronunciation, and so may you.

For a fuller list of terms, see the Glossary.